

VTUZ Classmates' Reunions

In 1967, we entered the Higher Technical College as first-year students — and, driven by the shared fear of failing our very first exams, we dove headfirst into studying. That's how our friendship began: not at a feast, but at a desk, between lectures and problem sets.



I already had a close friend — Mishka Golubev (we'd met years earlier, back in the kolkhoz). Soon after, Arkasha Bruk and Lyova Firsht joined us — or perhaps we joined them; truth be told, no one remembers exactly how it happened. In any case, we quickly became a group of four. We met every day, ate lunch together, went to the cinema — and, little by little, forged a friendship that has lasted a lifetime. And so it went — together, every day — until the very end of our studies.

Meanwhile, another company had formed: Edik Pil, Oleg Solyanik, Vova Korshunov, and Valera Zhelenin — a quartet bound by their own rhythm, their own jokes, their own path through the years.

The girls also had their own circles — for instance, there was a close-knit group of three: Larisa Golubeva (Fomina), Natasha Galchyonkova, and Lyuba Kraevskaya.

Another close circle included Ira Puchkova (Yartseva), Sveta Vaskova (Kotova), and Tamara Ivanova (Maslova) — all from Group 21.

The rest tended to form friendships in pairs, while some preferred to keep to themselves — and that, too, was perfectly alright.



For a long time, I was convinced we'd never manage to gather even our own study group — let alone the entire VTUZ cohort. After all, our cohort wasn't a unified "team": we were split into small, tight-knit circles of three or four, each with its own rhythm. I couldn't imagine us ever coming together — even for a simple group outing.

But life, as it happens, had other plans — and I was proven wrong.

One day, almost out of the blue, someone (Larisa Fomina? My memory hesitates, but my heart says yes) quietly began gathering us back.

And then — wonder of wonders — a handful of us boarded a train to Pskov. Not the whole cohort. Not even half. Just enough to prove that some bonds never truly break.

Then, after our third year, our Group 22 ensemble took third place in the VTUZ amateur arts competition — and as a prize, we were awarded a one-day bus trip to Tallinn.

Of course, the prize didn't come for free: we'd poured no small effort into preparing that performance.



Here, special thanks are due to our maestro — Arkady Bruk, who took charge of the entire preparation, and to Larisa Fomina, whose tireless initiative made it all happen.



And so — three numbers took shape:

- a humorous sketch, “Student and Professor”, performed by Bruk and Zilberman;
- the folk song “Oy, tsvetet kalina...” (“The Guelder Rose Is Blooming”);
- and the spirited anthem “Smelost’ goroda beret” (“Courage Conquers the City”).

For this, we won the prize — the unforgettable one-day trip to Tallinn.

There were twelve of us. The bus ride took eight hours; we arrived at ten in the evening.



We went straight to Vana-Thomas, a restaurant on Town Hall Square — where I still remember sipping the amber Vana Tallinn liqueur.

We spent the night in a local dormitory, and at dawn, a local guide led us through the cobbled streets of the Old Town.

After lunch — free time in small groups — then, at evening, we regrouped, boarded our bus again, and arrived back in Leningrad by morning.



Later, we kept gathering in the VTUZ assembly hall for holiday reunions — birthdays, New Year’s, Victory Day...

In 1973, our cohort completed its six-year programme at the Higher Technical Educational Institution affiliated with the Leningrad Metal Works (LMZ).

Our diploma projects were written right at the plant — in the Water Turbine Design Bureau.

After defending our diploma projects at the VTUZ and receiving our engineering diplomas, we were assigned to various workplaces across Leningrad — and, in a sense, scattered to the winds.

But first — right after the defence — something curious happened:

the girls were handed both their diplomas and graduate badges immediately.

We, the guys? Only the badges — the little poplavki (those hollow metal pins they jokingly called “floaters”, since they weighed next to nothing).

As for our diplomas?

“We’ll give them to you,” we were told, “after you complete the two-month military training.”

It took place in the Leningrad Region — at an armored unit base.

And so it was.

After defending our diploma projects at the VTUZ and receiving our engineering diplomas, we were assigned across Leningrad — and, in a sense, scattered to the winds.

But first — right after the defence — came a curious twist:

- the girls were handed their diplomas and graduation badges on the spot;
- we, the guys? Only the badges — those hollow little poplavki (we called them “floaters”, half-jokingly, because they weighed next to nothing).

As for our diplomas?

“We’ll issue them,” we were told, “after you complete the two-month military training — at the armored unit base in the Leningrad Region.”

And so it was.

Naturally, our entire group headed straight to Kareliya café, on Metallistov Avenue, to “baptise” those poplavki.

We didn’t stay long — just enough to drink some Kheres wine — before heading home.

I still remember: the world doubled before my eyes all the way home — from exhaustion, from wine, or, most likely, from both.

And then — just as the defences were over — Sasha Babeshkin dropped the news:

“I’ve got connections. We can celebrate our graduation at the Leningrad Hotel — in the real restaurant.”

No need to ask twice.

The banquet took place in June — and for the first (and only) time, nearly the whole cohort gathered: 28 of us, sitting around one table.

A few were absent: Solyanik, Potashev, Dmitrieva, Galchyonkova, and Fomina.

No instructors attended — and that, truly, was a pity.

We took photos, danced, laughed — celebrated as only those who’ve just crossed a life threshold can.

It was a truly wonderful banquet — a farewell, an otval’naya, as we used to say: a symbolic “launch” into the world.

We all sensed it then: this was the last time we’d ever be together — all 28 of us.

And yet — life kept bringing us back, if not as a cohort, then as smaller circles.

This was largely thanks to Eduard Pil, our indefatigable main organizer: he called everyone, coordinated schedules, made sure no one was forgotten.

To him — our deepest gratitude.

Of course, not everyone from the original intake could make it:

- some had been expelled after the first or second session,
- others joined mid-stream — only to leave before the finish line.

Such is the natural attrition of six years of study



Ресторан гостиницы "ЛЕНИНГРАД"
Выпускники ВТУЗа 1973г.

На фото: 1-Брук, 2-Фиршт, 3-Кипнис, 4-Сопоненко, 5-Дубилет, 6-Гольц, 7-Фомченко, 8-Васькова, 9-Иванова, 10-Малышев, 11-Пучкова, 12-Селезнёва, 13-Коршунов, 14-Кукин, 15-Волков, 16-Желенин, 17-Зильберман, 18-Ненахов, 19-Возняк, 20-Голубев, 21-Животягин, 22-Бабешкин, 23-Краевская, 24-Абрамов, 25-Короткина, 26-Соколова, 27-



But special thanks are owed to those who, long after graduation, opened their homes and hearts to host our reunions — marking this or that anniversary of our alma mater:

Lyova Firsht, Igor Nenakhov, and Misha Golubev.

True, some of the guys were drafted straight into the army — for two years, as officers. Igor Nenakhov, Kukin, Malyshev, and others were among them.

I, however, was not called up — and so I went straight to work at our Leningrad Metal Works (LMZ), even though my official assignment was to the LenGidroProject Research Institute.



But I wanted LMZ — and for good reasons:

- first, it was simply closer and more convenient to get to;
- second — and more importantly — I came from an LMZ dynasty.

My grandfather, Nikolai Vladimirovich Vladimirov, had once worked as a blacksmith in the forge shop — and perished during the Siege of Leningrad.

My elder brother, Oleg, was then working in the Steam Turbine Laboratory.

My uncle Vanya and his son Kolya — both in the Main Steam Turbine Shop.

Yet LenGidroProject refused to release me.

And LMZ was eager to take me — but my assignment voucher pointed elsewhere.

So I went to the LMZ Personnel Department.

“You’ll need to reissue the voucher,” they said.

I turned around — and headed straight to the VTUZ Personnel Office.

Its head — Mr. Miloshevich.

He listened to me in silence, thought for a moment — and then picked up an eraser, rubbed out “LenGidroProject” on the assignment voucher, and carefully wrote in “LMZ” by hand.

At the plant’s Personnel Department, they took one look — and, with perfect bureaucratic grace, pretended not to notice the correction.

Meeting at Lev Firsh't's place, June 11, 1983

Приглашаем Вас на юбилейную встречу выпускников, студентов и преподавателей, посвященную

25-летию со дня основания кафедры гидромашин

Встреча состоится

1 октября 1993 года

в актовом здании Санкт-Петербургского института машиностроения

Сбор в 15 ч 30 мин

Повестка дня:

1. Футбольный турнир —12 ч
2. Посадка аллеи гидромашиниста —14 ч
3. Торжественная часть —16 ч
4. Непоржественная часть —18 ч

25 ЛЕТ кафедре гидромашин

Адрес: Полустровский проспект, 14



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Also assigned to the LMZ (Leningrad Metal Works) were Arkady Bruk, Tamara Maslova (Ivanova), Irina Yartseva (Puchkova), Svetlana Kotova (Vaskova), Natalia Galchenkova, Alexander Malyshev, Anatoly Potashov, Valery Zhelenin, Mikhail Kipnis, Alexander Fomchenko, and Oleg Solyanik.

It seemed to me we'd never manage to gather our entire VTUZ graduation cohort — I thought that, since our cohort wasn't particularly close-knit, and everyone had long since split into small circles of three or four, we'd simply never come together again — as one.





But, as it later turned out, I was mistaken.

Our cohort consisted of two study groups: Group 21 and Group 22.

Group 21 had around 17 students:

Malyshev, Volkov, Izbuskin, Voznyak, Dubilet, Kipnis, Avramov, Nenakhov, Kukin, Zhivotyagin, Solonenko, Pismenny, Maslova (Ivanova), Korotkina, Irina Seleznyova — and, if I recall correctly, two more women.

Our Group 22 numbered about 18:

Pil, Golubev, Bruk, Firsht, Fomchenko, Solyanik, Zhelenin, Korshunov, Babeshkin, Potashev, Zilberman, Fomina (Golubeva), Yartseva (Puchkova), Kotova (Vaskova), Dmitrieva, Zakharova (Sokolova), Galchyonkova, Kraevskaya.

The first reunion was organized by Lyova Firsht — at his home, ten years after graduation, in 1983.

Eleven of us gathered — all men.

The date: 11 June 1983.

It was deeply moving to see the people with whom I'd shared six years of study.

By then, we'd scattered across the city and beyond — and only six of those present still worked at LMZ.

Then, roughly nine or ten years later — one summer — Eduard Pil and I got on the phone and decided: Let's take a small group to Peterhof, sit by the Gulf, on the pebbles.

And so, in the summer of 1992, we did just that:

bottles of vodka, simple sandwiches — and off we went to the shore.

This was our second reunion.

We were few — five or six, perhaps.

I remember: Pil, Malyshev, Izbuskin, Solyanik, Fomchenko... and maybe one more — but many were away at dachas or on holiday.

We sat right by the water's edge, talked for hours, then wandered off to see the fountains — and, as evening fell, headed home.

We did the very same the following summer, in 1993 — only this time, Solyanik wasn't with us, and Zhivotyagin had joined instead.

This was our third reunion.

Photos, I believe, were never taken.

Our fourth gathering took place back at the VTUZ — on 1 October 1993 — to mark the 25th anniversary of the Hydraulic Machinery Department.

Six or seven of us showed up.

And then — the next milestone: the 25th anniversary of our graduation, in the spring of 1998.

The venue: Igor Nenakhov's home.

He himself proposed it — and to him, we owe our deepest thanks.

That time, we gathered in the largest number since graduation: 16 people — and, remarkably, several women came too.

Some couldn't make it; others, sadly, were no longer with us.

Yet the evening was truly joyful — lively, full of laughter, even dancing.

Later, in May 2008, Lyova Firsht took the initiative again — and we met at the Pushkar pub on Pushkarskaya Street.

We had a private room, just our circle, and spent the evening catching up — sharing stories of how life had been.



1- Volkov B., 2- Pil E., 3- Malyshev A., 4- Dubilet S., 5- Nenakhov I., 6- Izbushkin A.,
7- Golubev M., 8- Bruk A., 9- Puchkova I., 10- Vaskova S., 11- Firsht L.

Then came the 40th anniversary of our VTUZ graduation, celebrated at a café in the Gulliver Business Centre.

I, unfortunately, couldn't attend — for a very good reason.

In 2018, we gathered again — this time at a café on Rizhskaya Street (many thanks to Izbushkin for organizing it).



We talked at length, exchanged news — but the table was almost too generous: an abundance of food and snacks.

Still, the mood wasn't quite right. A loud group sat nearby, and we felt constrained — not quite ourselves.

After all, someone's home is always better: simpler, warmer, freer.

Then came the milestone: 50 years since graduation.

For a long time, we couldn't manage to gather — no one quite stepped forward to organize it.



But finally — in 2024 — Misha Golubev invited us to his home, on the very day of his birthday: 23 March.



Firsht Lyova, Golubeva Larisa, Pil Eduard, and Golubev Mikle

I deeply regret not being there — my wife's illness kept me away.
 Time moves on. We've aged. Some are unwell; some can't travel; some are no longer with us.
 Yet four of them still came together.
 And may God grant — not for the last time.

NOTE *

The official first reunion took place one year after graduation — in the summer of 1974.

Eduard Pil began calling our fellow graduates, proposing we meet. He chose a weekend, near the Ploshchad Mira metro station — now historically renamed Sennaya Square (though back then, everyone called it “Palmira”).

Only three of us showed up: Eduard Pil, Alexander Zilberman, and Mikhail Kipnis. They decided to walk — the weather was glorious — to a nearby shashlychnaya (kebab house) at the corner of Sadovaya Street, 60, and Nikolskaya Street, famous for its cheap, delicious grilled meat. The place was nearly empty, so they sat by the window — with a view of St. Nicholas Cathedral — ordered shashlik and a bottle of white wine, and spent an easy, unhurried hour and a half in conversation. Afterwards, they strolled back to the metro and said goodbye. This meeting became historic: Alexander and Mikhail emigrated to the United States the following year.

Today, Alexander Zilberman lives in Florida — in his own home near the Gulf of Mexico — with his wife, elder daughter and granddaughter. His younger daughter works in show business. Mikhail Kipnis resides in Chicago. His granddaughter, Jordan, enrolled in a university near Chicago in 2025, aiming to become a manager.

A contemporary photo of that very kebab house — now transformed into a shop — is shown below. It saddens me deeply to see how the history of such beloved Leningrad institutions fades into oblivion. Yet this particular shashlychnaya was remarkably fortunate: it entered cinematic history — and anyone can still see it today in the film “Ver'te mne, lyudi” (“Believe Me, People”). But this shashlychnaya holds one more little secret: it was here that Mikhail Kipnis met his future wife, Elena, while standing in line with his friend, and she was there with her girlfriend.

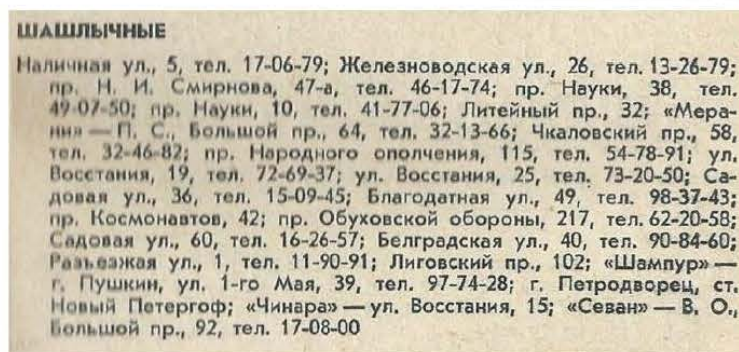
Below is a nostalgic list of those legendary shashlychnye — places where, in those now-distant years, the people's path never grew over. Sometimes, one even had to queue — just to sit cozily with friends, share stories, savour a skewer of grilled meat, and toast it with a glass of wine... or a shot of vodka.



Shashlychnaya (Kebab Restaurant). Corner of Sadovaya Street, 60, and Nikolsky Lane.
 Site of the first VTUZ alumni reunion in the summer of 1974.



Sadovaya Street, 60. Shashlychnaya operated by the Dining Halls Trust of the Oktyabrsky District. 1904.
 Still from the film “Believe Me, People” (“Ver'te mne, lyudi”).



Leningrad Shashlychnayas. Directory, 1973.

But life goes on through our children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren... And as the legendary singer Freddie Mercury of the band *Queen* sang, “The show must go on.”

— *Recollections of Alexander Fomchenko (VTUZ, 1973)*

— *English translation prepared by Eduard Pil*

* — *Addition made by Eduard Pil*